THE BHAGWAT DHARMA

Under Mohan Bhagwat's leadership, the RSS sharpened its stance, using the Lok Sabha election results to assert its influence and push for a recalibration in the BJP's approach

By Anilesh S. Mahajan



This year's Lok Sabha election results delivered an unexpected twist. The BJP's tumble from 303 to 240 seats, signalling a diminished aura for the Modi government, widened the ambit of political discourse. Opposition criticism could be predicted. The real shock came from the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), the BJP's ideological mentor.

RSS sarsanghchalak Mohan Bhagwat delivered a series of remarks that many believed to be a critique of the BJP's leadership, its campaign strategies, and even Prime Minister Narendra Modi himself. Bhagwat seemed to be articulating misgivings on several fronts. He criticised the divisive rhetoric employed by some BJP leaders, expressed unease with the Modi-centric narrative (Modi ki Guarantee) of the campaign, and lamented the lack of attention paid to feedback from RSS affiliates. He also raised questions about the absorption of politicians ideologically incompatible to the BJP.

Bhagwat, like his predecessors, is known for his measured critiques. Yet in July, during a meeting of village-level workers in Gumla, Jharkhand, his remarks came close to being a pointed rebuke. "In movies, they show Superman who has extraordinary powers. So a human wants to have such power... but he doesn't stop there. He then wants to become a Dev. But Devtas say Bhagwan is bigger than us, so then he wants to become Bhagwan," he said. Sangh insiders interpreted these words as a veiled critique of Modi's larger-than-life campaign persona.

For many within the organisation, Bhagwat's statements carried the weight of collective sentiment. A senior pracharak described them as the "inner voice" of swayamsevaks, the infantry that doubles up as BJP workers during elections.

Bhagwat's critiques had tangible effects. The BJP was forced to recalibrate its electoral strategy, moving away from the singular focus on Modi and placing the Sangh's agenda back on the table. This shift was evident in state elections such as those in Haryana and Maharashtra, where the RSS's guiding hand became more visible. However, the dynamic was likened by some to a "lover's tiff," with the BJP and RSS finding a new equilibrium rather than drifting apart. And the reconciliation process included both symbolic and practical gestures. The Centre's decision to rescind a five-decade-old circular barring government employees from attending RSS functions was seen as a gesture of goodwill.

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